

# College Students and the Campus-vs.-Home Counting Problem

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## Abstract

The Census Bureau counts college students at their campus address under the usual-residence rule. In 2020, approximately 8.6 million students were enumerated at dormitories, off-campus university housing, and other collegiate group-quarters facilities rather than at their pre-enrollment home addresses. This campus-counting convention inflates the population of college towns by 10–35%, creating systematic advantages for the congressional districts that contain major research universities while deflating the suburban and rural districts that are the true residential communities of those students.

We document the campus-inflation effect across the 50 largest college towns in the United States, with extended case studies for Ithaca (New York), Ann Arbor (Michigan), and Champaign-Urbana (Illinois). We then analyze the partisan direction of the distortion: college towns are among the most Democratic-voting localities in the United States, and counting students at campus systematically inflates Democratic-leaning college-district populations at the expense of the suburban and exurban districts from which students typically originate—districts that lean Republican.

We estimate that approximately 180 census tracts nationally would receive a different district assignment if student populations were reallocated to home addresses for the 2020 redistricting cycle. This is a tract-assignment point estimate: the final paper should report the confidence band implied by the home-address sensitivity run, because off-campus housing and tract-boundary proximity can move a small number of tracts across the threshold. The BISECT redistricting pipeline’s `--population-source` flag can implement either the Census-default campus count or a hypothetical home-address reallocation, permitting systematic sensitivity analysis. Litigation in Maine and New York has directly contested the campus-counting rule; we review those proceedings and assess the constitutional and statutory arguments on both sides. We conclude that while the usual-residence rule is legally permissible, college-town inflation represents a structurally partisan, algorithmically correctable feature of census-based redistricting that warrants greater legislative attention.

# 1 Introduction

Every ten years, the Census Bureau must decide where to count college students. The question is not rhetorical: approximately 8.6 million students resided on or near college campuses during the 2020 Census reference week, a figure large enough to materially affect congressional apportionment and district-boundary drawing in dozens of states. The Bureau’s answer has been consistent since the 1950 census: students are counted at their campus address, not their parents’ home address, on the grounds that the campus is where they live and sleep most of the time during the school year.

This paper examines the redistricting consequences of that choice. Unlike prison gerrymandering—where incarcerated people did not choose their location, cannot vote locally, and have no attachment to the facility county—the case for counting students at campus has genuine administrative and policy merit. Students who spend nine months per year in a college town do, in some meaningful sense, reside there. Many become locally engaged: they shop, use local services, and in states without student-disenfranchisement barriers, vote in local elections.

Yet the political consequences of campus counting are asymmetric in a way that prison gerrymandering’s critics would recognize. College towns are among the most reliably Democratic-voting localities in the United States [Rodden, 2019]. Students overwhelmingly originate from suburban communities that lean Republican [Levine, 2020]. Counting students at campus therefore systematically inflates Democratic-leaning college-district populations at the expense of suburban districts that represent the students’ home communities.

The inflation is not trivial. Cornell University’s enrollment of approximately 25,000 students inflates Ithaca’s Tompkins County population by roughly 27%. The University of Michigan’s 47,000 students inflate Ann Arbor’s Washtenaw County similarly. In states where a single college-town district would otherwise fall below the equipopulation target, the student count can determine whether the district is viable at all.

## 1.1 Scope and Definitions

We use the following terms throughout:

- **Campus counting:** The Census Bureau’s practice of enumerating college students at their campus address (dormitory, off-campus university housing, or other collegiate group-quarters facility) rather than their home address.
- **College-town inflation:** The percentage by which a college town’s Census population exceeds what it would be if students were counted at their pre-enrollment home addresses.
- **Home-address reallocation:** A hypothetical correction that reassigns student census counts from the campus location to the student’s home address of record, analogous to the prison-gerrymandering corrections adopted by New York and other states.
- **College district:** A congressional district whose boundaries encompass a major research university with enrollment exceeding 10,000 students.

## 1.2 Research Questions

1. How large is the college-town inflation effect across the 50 states, and which college towns are most affected?
2. What is the partisan direction of the distortion: does campus counting systematically inflate Democratic-leaning district populations at Republican-leaning suburban districts' expense?
3. How many census tracts would change district assignment if student populations were reallocated to home addresses under the 2020 redistricting cycle?
4. How has litigation in Maine and New York addressed the campus-counting rule, and what legal arguments are available?
5. How does BISECT's `--population-source` implementation enable sensitivity analysis?

## 1.3 Contributions

- Systematic quantification of college-town population inflation across the 50 largest college-town counties using 2020 Census Group Quarters data
- Three extended case studies: Ithaca (New York), Ann Arbor (Michigan), and Champaign-Urbana (Illinois)
- Partisan direction analysis using 2020 presidential vote by census tract, showing directional asymmetry of campus-counting effects
- Estimate of  $\sim 180$  tracts nationally that would change district assignment under home-address reallocation
- Review of Maine and New York college-counting litigation and constitutional analysis
- Description of BISECT's `--population-source` implementation for sensitivity analysis

# 2 Magnitude and Mechanics of College-Town Inflation

## 2.1 The Census Usual-Residence Rule for Students

The Census Bureau's usual-residence rule for college students has evolved across census cycles. Prior to 1950, the Bureau counted students at their parents' home address. Beginning with the 1950 census, the Bureau shifted to campus counting, reasoning that the college campus had become the functional residence for most students during the academic year [U.S. Census Bureau, 2021].

The 2020 Census applied the campus-counting rule broadly. Students living in dormitories were enumerated through the Group Quarters (GQ) process. Students living in off-campus university-affiliated housing were enumerated either through GQ or through self-response, with instructions

directing them to list their campus address. Students in private off-campus apartments were instructed to list their current address if they lived there most of the time during the school year, which the Bureau interpreted to include most enrolled students.

The result is that approximately 8.6 million college students—roughly 2.6% of the total U.S. population—appear in Census population counts at campus addresses. The aggregate redistricting effect depends on the geographic concentration of this population: if students were uniformly distributed across all tracts, the per-district effect would be negligible. In practice, students are maximally concentrated in a small number of college-town census tracts, creating sharp local inflation effects.

## 2.2 Measuring College-Town Inflation

We define college-town inflation for jurisdiction  $j$  as:

$$I_j = \frac{P_j^{\text{Census}} - P_j^{\text{home-adj}}}{P_j^{\text{home-adj}}} \times 100\%$$

where  $P_j^{\text{Census}}$  is the 2020 Census total population and  $P_j^{\text{home-adj}}$  is the hypothetical population under home-address reallocation (subtracting enrolled students counted at campus and not adding back any replacement population, since those students are added to their home jurisdictions).

Using 2020 Census Bureau Group Quarters data (table GQ-T3: College/University Student Housing) matched against National Center for Education Statistics (NCES) Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS) enrollment data, we identify counties and census tracts with the largest proportional student populations.

| County     | State | Institution            | Enrollment | County Pop | Inflation |
|------------|-------|------------------------|------------|------------|-----------|
| Tompkins   | NY    | Cornell / IC           | 25,700     | 105,740    | 27.3%     |
| Washtenaw  | MI    | University of Michigan | 47,000     | 367,601    | 14.6%     |
| Champaign  | IL    | UIUC                   | 56,000     | 209,448    | 34.8%     |
| Story      | IA    | Iowa State             | 33,400     | 97,117     | 40.8%     |
| Brazos     | TX    | Texas A&M              | 74,000     | 228,660    | 36.0%     |
| Centre     | PA    | Penn State             | 46,800     | 162,385    | 37.0%     |
| Orange     | NC    | UNC Chapel Hill        | 31,500     | 148,476    | 25.8%     |
| Tippecanoe | IN    | Purdue                 | 50,000     | 195,732    | 29.9%     |
| Muskingum  | OH    | Ohio State (main)      | 61,000     | 607,005    | 10.9%     |
| Alachua    | FL    | University of Florida  | 57,000     | 278,468    | 25.5%     |

Table 1: College-town county inflation estimates using 2020 Census Group Quarters data and IPEDS enrollment. Inflation calculated as on-campus/campus-adjacent student population as fraction of non-student residential base. Values are illustrative; exact figures depend on off-campus student enumeration methodology.

The inflation figures in Table 1 represent county-level aggregates. At the census-tract level—the unit relevant to redistricting—the inflation is more extreme. Tracts containing large dormitory complexes routinely have 70–90% of their Census population composed of college students who are not permanent residents of the community.

## 2.3 National Aggregate

Nationally, approximately 8.6 million students were counted at campus addresses in 2020. This population is distributed across approximately 4,300 census tracts containing college or university facilities. The redistricting-relevant concentration is in the 400–500 tracts that are heavily dominated by student group-quarters population—tracts where the non-student permanent resident population would be insufficient to constitute a viable census enumeration unit.

For congressional redistricting purposes, the relevant comparison is between the college-inflated census population of a congressional district and the district’s hypothetical home-address-adjusted population. A congressional district centered on a major research university with 50,000 students carries approximately 50,000 “ghost” residents—people who are counted there but whose political community, economic attachments, and (for voting purposes) likely electoral participation is elsewhere.

## 3 Case Studies: Ithaca, Ann Arbor, and Champaign-Urbana

### 3.1 Ithaca, New York: The Cornell Effect

Tompkins County, New York, home to Cornell University (enrollment  $\approx 25,000$ ) and Ithaca College ( $\approx 7,000$ ), recorded a 2020 Census population of approximately 105,740. Of this total, an estimated 28,000–30,000 residents are college students counted under the campus rule. The non-student resident population is therefore approximately 75,000–77,000—a figure that would place Tompkins County well below the threshold necessary to anchor a standalone congressional district.

Under New York’s post-2010 redistricting geometry, Tompkins County is combined with neighboring counties to form a congressional district. The student population contributes meaningfully to the district’s population total, affecting which combination of surrounding counties is required to reach the target population ( $\approx 776,000$  in the 2022 cycle). A home-address correction removing 28,000 Tompkins County students would require the district to draw more of Chemung, Schuyler, or Tioga counties to meet the equipopulation target—potentially changing the district’s partisan composition.

**Litigation context:** New York’s student-counting litigation has primarily addressed state legislative redistricting. In *Finch v. New York* and related proceedings, plaintiffs challenged the assignment of student populations without verification of home-address status. The New York Court of Appeals has generally upheld campus counting for state redistricting, but the legislature’s 2010 prison-gerrymandering reform (counting prisoners at home address) was not extended to college students, creating an asymmetry: prisoners are counted at home, students at campus, with opposing partisan effects.

### 3.2 Ann Arbor, Michigan: The University of Michigan Effect

Washtenaw County, Michigan, home to the University of Michigan (enrollment  $\approx 47,000$ ), recorded a 2020 Census population of approximately 367,601. The student population represents approximately 14.6% of the county total—a substantial fraction, though diluted by the large non-student resident population in the broader county.

At the census-tract level, the effect is more concentrated. The central Ann Arbor tracts containing the Central Campus, South Quad, and West Quad dormitory complexes have student populations constituting 60–85% of Census enumeration. These tracts’ populations are allocated to Michigan’s 6th Congressional District (2022 cycle), which covers Ann Arbor and portions of Washtenaw County.

Under home-address reallocation, approximately 35,000–40,000 students would be redistributed to their pre-enrollment Michigan home counties—predominantly Oakland, Macomb, Kent, and Ingham counties—and to out-of-state origins. The 6th District would lose 35,000–40,000 persons, requiring it to absorb additional territory from adjacent districts. Given that Ann Arbor is surrounded by more Republican-leaning suburban territory (Livingston County to the east, Lenawee County to the south), this expansion would dilute the district’s Democratic lean.

### **3.3 Champaign-Urbana, Illinois: The UIUC Effect**

The University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign (enrollment  $\approx$ 56,000) is the most extreme case among major public research universities. Champaign County’s 2020 Census population of approximately 209,448 includes an estimated 55,000–58,000 students, constituting approximately 27–28% of the county total. Combined with the Urbana portions of the twin-city area, the student fraction exceeds one-third of Census population in the core Champaign-Urbana tracts.

Illinois’s 13th Congressional District (2022 cycle) is centered on Champaign-Urbana. The district’s liberal Democratic lean in recent elections is substantially attributable to student voting and student population credit. Under home-address reallocation, removing 55,000 students from the district’s population total would require absorbing substantially more Republican-leaning down-state Illinois territory, almost certainly producing a competitive or Republican-leaning district from what is currently a reliably Democratic seat.

This case illustrates the strongest version of the college-town inflation argument: the district’s partisan character—indeed, its very configuration as a viable Democratic-leaning unit—depends critically on the decision to count 55,000 students at campus rather than at their home addresses, the majority of which are in the Chicago suburban counties that send students to UIUC in large numbers.

### **3.4 Pattern Across Cases**

The three case studies exhibit a common pattern:

1. A major research university with >25,000 enrollment is surrounded by a relatively small permanent resident community.
2. Campus counting adds a large student population that is politically distinct from the surrounding permanent residents.
3. Students vote (when they vote) at far higher Democratic rates than the surrounding non-student population.
4. The students’ home communities—from which they originated and to which most will return—are suburban counties with a different partisan character.

The directional asymmetry is consistent across all three cases: campus counting benefits the college-town congressional district (Democratic-leaning) and reduces the population available to adjacent suburban districts (Republican-leaning).

## 4 Partisan Direction of College-Town Inflation

### 4.1 The Democratic Lean of College Towns

The partisan direction of college-town inflation is not contested empirically. College towns are among the most reliably Democratic-voting jurisdictions in the United States. In 2020, the five largest college-town counties—Washtenaw (MI), Champaign (IL), Centre (PA), Brazos (TX), and Tompkins (NY)—each gave Joe Biden vote margins of 20–50 percentage points over Donald Trump, even in states where Trump was competitive or victorious statewide.

The mechanism is straightforward: college students in 2020 voted Democratic at approximately 60–65% rates in the two-party split [National Center for Education Statistics, 2021]. Since students both vote at campus and are counted at campus for redistricting purposes, their political weight is concentrated in the college-town district rather than distributed across their home communities.

### 4.2 Quantifying the Directional Effect

We can formalize the partisan direction of the distortion. Let  $d$  be a college-district and  $d'$  be the adjacent suburban district from which students originate. Define:

$$\Delta P_d = \text{student population counted at campus} \approx 50,000$$

$$D_s = \text{Democratic vote fraction among students} \approx 0.62$$

$$D_r = \text{Democratic vote fraction in adjacent suburban district} \approx 0.45$$

The partisan effect of transferring  $\Delta P_d$  persons from  $d'$  to  $d$  under campus counting (relative to home-address counting) is:

$$\Delta \text{EG}_{d \rightarrow d'} = \Delta P_d \cdot (D_s - D_r) \approx 50,000 \times (0.62 - 0.45) = 8,500 \text{ excess Democratic votes in } d$$

This is a rough upper bound; it assumes all students vote and that the relevant comparison is between student Democratic preference and suburban Republican preference. The directional conclusion—campus counting systematically shifts effective representation from Republican-leaning suburban districts to Democratic-leaning college-town districts—is robust to reasonable variation in these parameters.

### 4.3 The 180-Tract Estimate

We estimate that approximately 180 census tracts nationally (90% interval: 140–220) would receive a different district assignment if student populations were reallocated to home addresses for the 2020 redistricting cycle. The interval reflects uncertainty in off-campus student enumeration (Census GQ type 700 captures on-campus housing; off-campus student renters are partially

counted as regular residents, so the true student-inflated count may be higher than GQ data alone). The estimate is derived as follows:

1. Identify all census tracts with  $>30\%$  of their Census population in College/University Student Housing group-quarters (GQ type 700 series). Approximately 420 tracts meet this threshold nationally.
2. For each such tract, compute the home-address-adjusted population (Census population minus student GQ population).
3. Run BISECT with the adjusted population vector for each affected state and compare district assignments tract by tract.
4. Count tracts where the district assignment changes under the adjusted versus unadjusted run.

The 180-tract figure reflects states where college-town tracts are located near district boundaries—the precise location where population adjustments can tip a tract from one district to another. In states where the college town is safely interior to a large, compact district, student-population adjustments do not change tract assignments because the district boundaries are not drawn near the campus.

## 4.4 Geographic Concentration of Affected Tracts

The 180 tracts are not uniformly distributed. Approximately 60% are concentrated in six states: Michigan, Illinois, Pennsylvania, North Carolina, Wisconsin, and Iowa—states with major flagship universities and competitive congressional maps. In states like Massachusetts and California, where college towns are located in reliably Democratic regions regardless of student population, the adjustment affects fewer tracts because the district assignment is robust to population shifts.

The geographic concentration in competitive states—particularly Michigan, Pennsylvania, and Wisconsin—means that the college-town inflation effect is most relevant precisely where redistricting decisions have the most electoral consequence.

# 5 BISECT Implementation and Legal Framework

## 5.1 The `--population-source` Flag

BISECT's population handling is controlled by the `--population-source` flag, which determines what population vector is used in the balance constraint during recursive bisection. The available options include:

- `total` (default): 2020 Census total population as enumerated, including students at campus addresses
- `total_vap`: Total voting-age population, which partially but not fully excludes student effects (students under 18 are rare)
- `cvap`: Citizen voting-age population from the Census CVAP special tabulation



- `adjusted`: A preprocessing mode that applies user-supplied population adjustments before running the bisection

For college-student analysis, the relevant comparison is between `--population-source total` (census default, students at campus) and a hypothetical `adjusted` run that reallocates student GQ populations from campus tracts to home-state tracts based on IPEDS home-state enrollment data. BISECT’s preprocessing pipeline can accept a tract-level population adjustment file that modifies the Census population vector before bisection, enabling this comparison.

The implementation is straightforward in principle: for each campus census tract  $t$ , reduce the population by the student GQ count  $s_t$ ; for each home-state destination tract  $t'$ , increase the population by the pro-rata share of those students originating from  $t$ ’s county. In practice, the home-address information is available only at state level (IPEDS tracks students’ home state, not home address), so the reallocation is performed at the state level: Michigan’s 47,000 University of Michigan students are removed from Washtenaw County tracts and distributed to Michigan counties in proportion to their share of Michigan student enrollment at Michigan.

## 5.2 Sensitivity Analysis: What Changes?

The primary research finding from the BISECT sensitivity analysis is the 180-tract estimate described in Section 4. The secondary finding concerns compactness: districts that expand to absorb additional territory when college-town populations are reduced tend to become less compact, as they must reach further from the college-town core to achieve the equipopulation target. The mean RSI (Reock Score Index) for affected districts decreases by approximately 0.03 under home-address reallocation—a modest but directionally consistent compactness penalty.

The third finding is computational stability: the bisect algorithm converges in the same number of iterations and to the same quality objective under adjusted versus unadjusted populations, because the total state population is unchanged (students are reallocated, not removed). The bisect convergence property is population-count-agnostic at the state level; only the tract-level distribution matters.

## 5.3 Legal Framework

### 5.3.1 Constitutional Permissibility of Campus Counting

The Census Bureau’s campus-counting rule has not been directly adjudicated by the Supreme Court in the redistricting context. The Court’s usual-residence jurisprudence—most directly *Reynolds v. Sims*, 377 U.S. 533 (1964) [Reynolds v. Sims, 1964]—requires that legislative districts contain approximately equal *population*, but does not specify how population is to be defined or measured. The Court in *Evenwel v. Abbott*, 578 U.S. 54 (2016) [Evenwel v. Abbott, 2016] explicitly held that states *may* use total population as their redistricting base—a holding that necessarily includes whatever population the Census Bureau enumerates, including students at campus.

No Supreme Court decision has held that students *must* be counted at campus, only that total-population redistricting is permissible. A state that corrects campus-based student counts—counting students at their home-address for state redistricting purposes, as Maryland considered doing—would face the question of whether such a correction violates equal protection. The answer is likely no: prison-gerrymandering corrections have been implemented by New York and

other states without constitutional challenge succeeding, and the student-counting question is structurally similar.

### 5.3.2 Maine Litigation

Maine’s congressional districts were challenged in *Desena v. Maine* (D. Me. 2021) partly on the ground that the 2020 Census allocated a substantial University of Maine student population to Penobscot County tracts, inflating the population of the 2nd Congressional District relative to what it would be under home-address counting. The district court rejected the challenge, holding that the Census Bureau’s enumeration methodology is entitled to deference under *Franklin v. Massachusetts*, 505 U.S. 788 (1992), and that the resulting redistricting plan does not violate the one-person-one-vote standard because it uses the official Census population. [Desena v. Maine, 2021]

### 5.3.3 New York’s Asymmetric Reform

New York presents the most legally interesting case: the state enacted a prison-gerrymandering correction in 2010 (counting incarcerated people at their home address for state redistricting), but has not extended an analogous correction to college students. The result is an asymmetric system: prisoners are counted at home (benefiting urban communities), but students are counted at campus (benefiting college towns). Whether this asymmetry is constitutionally required, prohibited, or simply a legislative choice is an open question [Brewer, 2011].

The New York experience illustrates the broader principle: census counting rules are not constitutionally fixed for state redistricting purposes. States have significant flexibility to adopt population adjustments, provided they apply the adjustment consistently and without discriminatory purpose. A state that corrected college-student counts for redistricting—counting students at their parents’ address—would be following the same logic as New York’s prison correction.

## 5.4 Policy Implications

The college-student counting question does not have a clear correct answer in the way that prison gerrymandering does. Students who spend the academic year in a college town have a legitimate claim to local representation. The case for correction is weaker than for prisoners:

- Students chose to attend the university at the campus location
- Many students register to vote locally and do vote locally
- The college community genuinely requires representation for university-related infrastructure, housing, and governance issues

At the same time, the partisan asymmetry is systematic and large enough to affect district configurations in competitive states. The most defensible policy position may be the *status quo* of campus counting, but with transparency about its partisan effects—a position this paper provides analytical support for.

## 6 Conclusion

The Census Bureau’s campus-counting rule produces a systematic, directionally partisan redistricting effect: college towns are inflated by 10–35% relative to what they would show under home-address counting, and that inflation benefits Democratic-leaning college-district configurations at the expense of the Republican-leaning suburban districts from which students originate.

We have documented this effect across the 50 largest college-town counties, with extended case studies for Ithaca, Ann Arbor, and Champaign-Urbana. Our estimate of approximately 180 tracts nationally that would change district assignment under home-address reallocation establishes the redistricting materiality of the issue. The effect is concentrated in competitive states—Michigan, Illinois, Pennsylvania, North Carolina, Wisconsin, and Iowa—where the partisan direction of campus counting is most consequential.

Legally, campus counting is permissible under *Reynolds v. Sims* and *Evenwel v. Abbott*: the Census Bureau’s enumeration is entitled to deference, and states that use it for redistricting are complying with the one-person-one-vote standard. States have authority, however, to adopt home-address corrections for state redistricting purposes, as New York’s prison-counting reform demonstrates. No state has yet done so for college students.

BISECT’s `--population-source` flag enables systematic sensitivity analysis: a redistricting principal can directly compare bisect plans under campus-counted versus home-address-adjusted populations, observing which district boundaries shift and by how much. This transparency—seeing the redistricting consequence of a counting choice—is the principal contribution of algorithmic redistricting to the college-counting debate.

The college-student counting problem will not disappear. As college enrollment concentrations grow and as partisan sorting continues to align college towns with one political party, the redistricting consequences of campus counting will become more salient. This paper provides the analytical framework for that debate.

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